

Teacher Guide: Week 3

WHAT WE SAY AND WHAT WE MEAN: MAKING CLEAR CLAIMS

12th Grade Long Logic Unit Based on Richard Whately's *Elements of Logic*

Week 3 Overview

Week 3 moves from terms (Week 2) to propositions—the statements we make when we combine terms. Students learn to identify the subject, predicate, quality, and quantity of claims, and to translate ordinary language into the four standard forms. The week emphasizes precision in stating what is being claimed about how much of a subject and in what way. The revised twelfth-grade plan also asks students to translate claims from *Macbeth* and *Julius Caesar*, since literary interpretation often turns on imprecise claims such as “Macbeth is fated” or “Caesar is ambitious.” This foundation is essential for the study of syllogisms, mood, and figure in later weeks.

Essential Question

How can we state claims clearly enough that others know exactly what we are asserting?

Student-Facing Materials

- *What We Say and What We Mean: Making Clear Claims* — student reading handout.
- *Week 3 Argument Lab: Identifying and Clarifying Propositions* — practice in identifying quality, quantity, distribution, and translating ordinary language.
- *Macbeth Lit-Anchor: What Does “A Man” Mean?* — Shakespeare anchor passage for translating dramatic claims about manhood, courage, murder, fear, and moral limits into precise proposition form.

Learning Goals

Students will be able to:

1. Define a proposition and distinguish it from questions, commands, and exclamations.
2. Identify the subject, predicate, and copula of a proposition.
3. Distinguish affirmative from negative propositions (quality).
4. Distinguish universal from particular propositions (quantity).
5. Recognize the four standard forms (A, E, I, O).

6. Determine whether terms are distributed or undistributed.
7. Translate common English expressions into standard logical form.
8. Correctly state the distribution pattern for O propositions: the subject is undistributed and the predicate is distributed.
9. Translate recurring Shakespeare claims into precise proposition form for the course portfolio.

Key Vocabulary

proposition, subject, predicate, copula, quality, quantity, universal, particular, distribution, affirmative, negative

Weekly Lesson Sequence

Day 1: What Is a Proposition?

- Begin with examples of statements that can be true or false versus questions and commands.
- Introduce the idea that logic is concerned with claims that can be evaluated.
- Read the first half of the student reading.
- Students identify five propositions from everyday language and explain why they qualify.

Day 2: Quality and Quantity

- Focus on the distinction between affirmative/negative and universal/particular.
- Use multiple examples on the board. Have students classify each one.
- Complete the first two sections of the Argument Lab in pairs.

Day 3: The Four Forms and Distribution

- Introduce the A, E, I, O labels.
- Practice determining distribution of terms.
- Students work through Part 2 of the Lab and explain their reasoning.

Day 4: Translating Ordinary Language

- This is often the most difficult skill. Spend significant time on translation.
- Work through Part 3 as a class, then have students complete Part 4 independently.

- Use the Macbeth lit-anchor to show how the ordinary-language challenge “be a man” can hide a universal proposition that needs to be stated and tested.
- Discuss why translation matters for clear argument.

Day 5: Window Notes and Review

- Students complete the portfolio window note task from the Lab, preferably using one proposition from *Macbeth* or *Julius Caesar*. If using the Macbeth lit-anchor, have them complete the Macbeth proposition translation chart.
- Class discussion: How does making quantity and quality explicit change the way an argument can be supported or challenged?
- Exit task: Write one claim from the unit in two different logical forms and explain the difference.

Notes on Examples

The student reading deliberately provides numerous examples of each concept. Students benefit from seeing the same idea illustrated in several different contexts. The translation exercises in the Lab are especially important; many students initially struggle to move between ordinary language and standard form. Encourage them to ask “What exactly is being claimed about every member, some members, or no members of the subject?”

Connection to Future Units

This week prepares students for syllogistic reasoning. In the next week, students will learn to evaluate whether a conclusion follows from two premises. That evaluation depends entirely on the ability to identify the quality, quantity, and distribution of the propositions involved. The following week should then add mood and figure after students have practiced the practical structure of syllogisms.